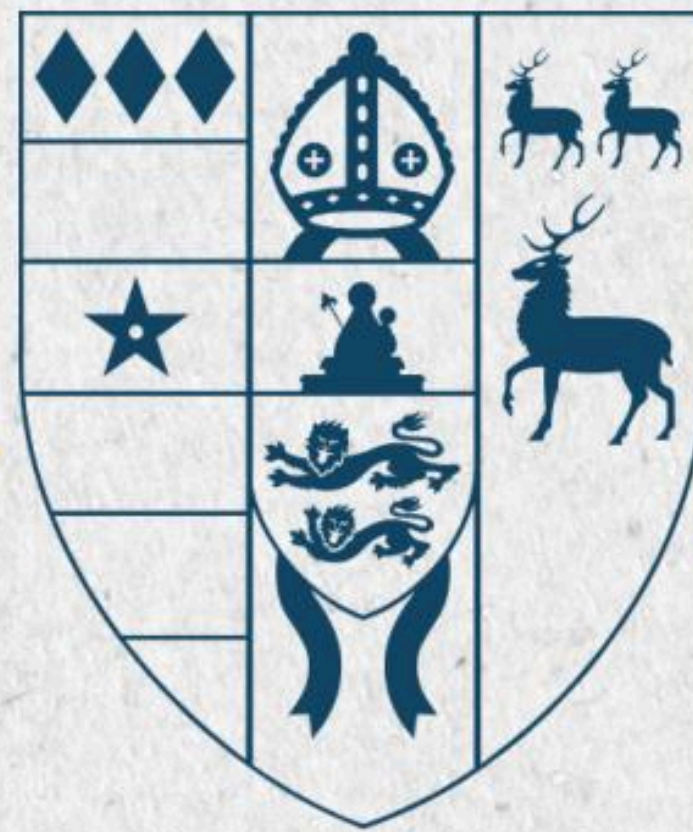




Lincoln

International Freshers' Guide

2026-2027

Contents

- 3 - Introduction*
- 4 - Arrival*
- 5 - Accommodation*
- 7 - Essentials: Documents
& Banking*
- 9 - Essentials: Phones &
Laundry*
- 10 - Essentials: Medical
Services & Welfare*
- 11 - Packing*
- 13 - Home Away from Home*
- 16 - Final Advice*



Introduction

Heya! Welcome to Lincoln!

My name is Christian, and I'm your JCR International Students representative this year! My dad and extended family are English, but I've lived my whole life in the SF Bay Area in California! As I'm half Taiwanese, I can also speak Mandarin.



Lincoln is a smaller college, which is known for its tight-knit community. While this may mean that there are fewer international students than at other colleges, we have a wonderful community here in Lincoln, and it's our goal to make sure you don't feel isolated while also navigating a new environment. I am here to help with logistical or moving issues, but also to organize events and activities so you can feel more at home away from your actual home.

There will be plenty of opportunities to meet fellow international students during Freshers' Week, so stay tuned. I'll also be working with the Cultural, Racial, and Ethnic Diversity (CRED) representative this year to improve college life for international students and students from different national and cultural backgrounds. All in all, be excited for an amazing year to come!

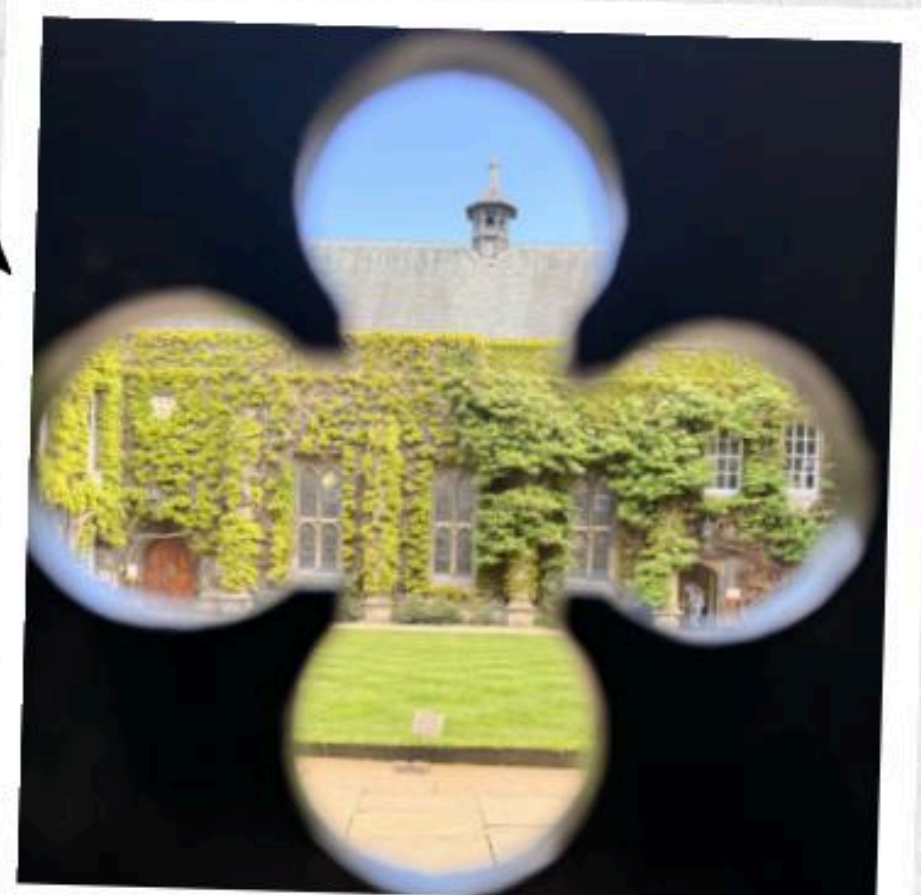
In the meantime, if you have any concerns or want to reach out to ask any questions, you can email me at christian.wang@lincoln.ox.ac.uk.

You can also reach me on: WhatsApp: +44 7943 596490
Instagram: @christiangwang



you can spot Lincoln's Library on High Street!

our beautiful Front Quad!



*this edition of the International Freshers Guide wouldn't be possible without that of Marysia Mezykowska's last year :)

Arriving at Lincoln



Lincoln College is situated in the heart of Oxford, along beautiful Turl Street. It's one of three colleges on that street, so if you're unsure which one it is, look for the Missing Bean Café; Lincoln is directly across from it! When you first arrive, go to the Lodge (staffed 24/7), where our Porters will direct you further. Your arrival date is Sunday (4th of October), but if this is not possible, you may request an arrival from the 2nd of October (subject to the approval of the accomodation team).

Getting from Heathrow

Most of you will be flying to Heathrow. The easiest way of getting to Lincoln is by bus. The airline bus departs approximately every 20 minutes (during the day). The first bus departs at 2 am and the last one leaves at midnight. You can purchase a ticket directly from the driver when you board the bus; however, if you manage to book two weeks in advance, the fares will be cheaper. If you arrive at Terminal 2 or 3, or at Terminal 4, you will depart from Central Bus Station. If you arrive at Terminal 5, the closest bus stop will be Stand 10.

Getting from Gatwick

There is a similar service as from Heathrow. The bus departs every hour from the North and South Terminals.

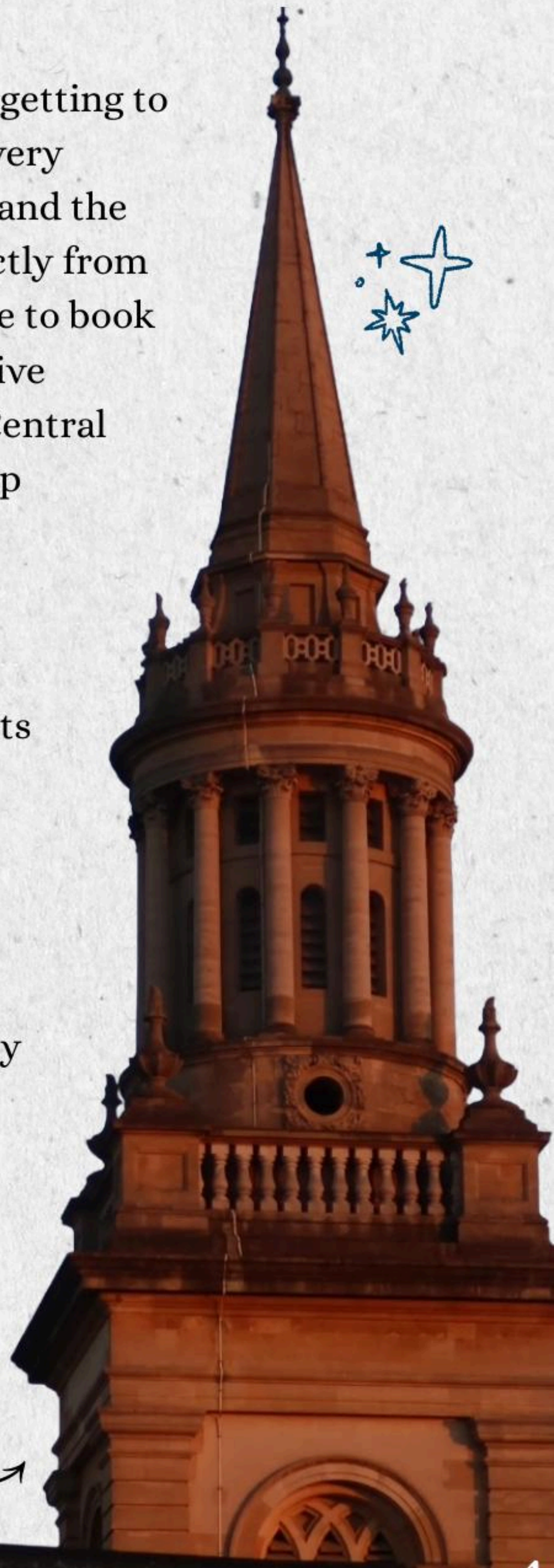
Getting to Lincoln

If you are taking the bus, the closest bus stop is Queen's Lane (6-minute walk), or you can go to the final stop, Gloucester Green (8-minute walk). If you are getting here by train, the Oxford Train Station is a 15-minute walk from Lincoln

More information about arriving in Oxford can be found [here](#).

*Note: To get to Oxford from London, trains from London run either from Paddington (GWR, faster but more expensive) or Marylebone (Chiltern Railways, cheaper but slower). Alternatively, the 'Oxford Tube' coach leaves from Victoria.

you can also spot our Library at the end of Turl Street



Accommodation



my first year room, Staircase 13 Room 10 :)

Your Room

All of the first-year rooms are single en-suite, and some of the rooms even have double beds. Every room will have:

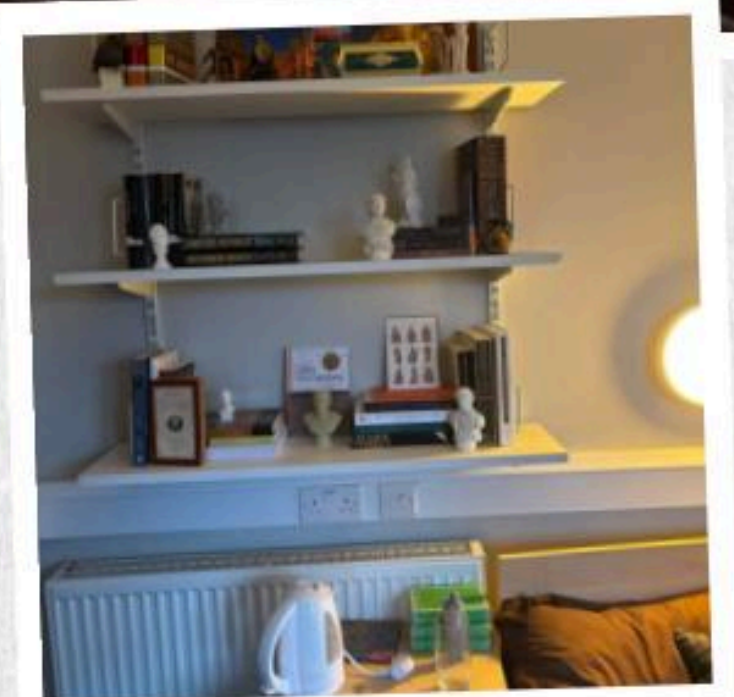
- Bed (without any bedsheets)
- Desk and chair
- Wardrobe
- Kettle
- There may also be additional storage space or furniture if space allows
- A few rooms will also have a mini-fridge

If your room does not come with a mini fridge, you can purchase one after you arrive (the cheapest option is to buy one second-hand; we typically have a sale in Michaelmas for freshers to buy second-hand fridges). While you will have to get your own bedding, it will definitely be easier to buy it in Oxford instead of bringing it from home (there is a John Lewis in Westgate, 10 min walk from Lincoln). Keep in mind that in first year, you do not have access to a kitchen, so no need to bring any kitchenware.

Some Tips

- Some rooms come with double beds, so I'd recommend buying a double duvet as well. Even if you have a single, it means you'll stay warm and cozy in the winter!
- I'd not recommend packing bedding/towels etc., as it takes a lot of room and can be easily bought at nearby stores like M&S or John Lewis.
- Some of the rooms are up a *lot* of stairs, so also be mindful of the weight of suitcases/boxes when packing.

a room in Lincoln House!



Accommodation ✨

Storage

For the first two years, you will be on a 3-term contract, which means you will have to fully move out of your room after each term ends. If you have an overseas status, you will be eligible for storage in college over the vac (trunk room is located in Lincoln House). Storage is generally unlimited, but you have to fill out a form beforehand (e-mails are sent out by Porters in due course). Try to get this done at least a few days before you need to put your stuff in the storage room. Your mini fridge can be stored in the bike shed (between Staircase 15 and Lincoln House).

'Vac Res'

One academic year consists of three terms (Michaelmas, Hilary, and Trinity), with each term being 8 weeks long. However, you will most likely arrive before week 1 – in 0th week (Sunday, Week 0 of each term is when your accommodation contract begins), due to Freshers' Week and, in the future, 'collections.' It is also possible that you will have to stay in Oxford in week 9, for example, for your exams (e.g., Mods and Prelims). In order to be able to stay in college past week 8 (or arrive before week 0), you will need to book 'vac res' (vacation residence). Whether you're granted vac res will depend on the availability of rooms, as the college rents out the rooms for various events. You are guaranteed to get vac res if you have to stay due to College or University exams. There is also a vac res grant (around £12/day) that you can apply for on the Lincoln website ;)

If you need to stay completely over the vac, you'll have to apply for full vac res in the application sent out for those staying later after term, not in the applications for those arriving early. You should typically check the "International Student" option.

Essentials

Documents

If you are an overseas student, you will have to apply for a visa before arriving in Oxford. More information can be found on the [University's website](#). Lincoln will also require you to upload relevant documentation onto the College's visa portal. More information can be found [here](#). For convenience, print out your share code and CAS letter before you leave home to show at the airport.

There are two other things I'll note that may be good to know. First, in addition to your passport and visa documentation, I'd also bring an ID (e.g., driver's license, provisional license, or Real ID) to use as proof so you can keep your passport safe in your room. Second, for medical care, you'll be given an NHS number in your pigeonhole (pigeonhole) when you arrive at Lincoln following registering at the King Edward Street at the Northgate Medical Practice. You'll be able to find all relevant information you need for this and other documentation on the Undergraduate Freshers' Hub, and later on in the Medical Services section.

Banking

It is essential to have access to money in your first few weeks in the UK (either cash or your home country bank account). Personally, I have an HSBC and a Lloyds account, but I know many international students also use Revolut, Monzo etc. I'd recommend a high street bank primarily for the ease of withdrawing money and the fact that you can always walk in if you have any trouble with your account. While most places in Oxford accept contactless payment, there are a few shops/restaurants that still use cash (e.g., Tse Noodle, SHIN).

I personally struggled a lot to open a UK bank account, so I'd be happy to help anyone with the process. But to sum it up, to open a UK bank account, you will need:

- Passport/ID
- Proof of residence (this can include evidence of your UK address or your Student Enrolment Certificate, which can be downloaded after completing your university registration, which typically occurs during Freshers' Week).
- Personal and employment/income details

More info can be found [here](#).

Essentials

Banking (cont.)

For the two banks that I have experience opening accounts with:

- For HSBC, opening accounts is primarily done through the mobile app. If you choose to go with HSBC, they'll call you a few days after you send in your application to verify your identity without having to prove your UK address (some international students did this before they arrived in the UK). The process may be finicky, though; while some people did it easily, it took me three tries to open an HSBC account.
 - If you are able to go to an HSBC branch in the UK, however, you can open an account in person with your passport and proof of residence.
- Lloyds is also done via the app, though I found it was easier to go to the branch to fill out the application and prove my residency there (e.g., I was able to prove my residency there via a family member's phone number and it was approved within one hour). If you have a certificate of enrollment or bank letter, that would also work.

Two more things to note: (1) you can only apply for a UK phone plan once you have a UK bank account, and many banks ask for proof of residency via a UK phone number. If you are prepared (unlike me), you won't fall into this trap. (2) You typically will not be eligible for student accounts as they require residency within the UK for the past three years, so I would primarily consider the ease of opening an account and the services the bank may offer after you graduate (i.e., if you continue to live in the UK) when deciding which bank to open an account with. Again, please reach out if you have any further questions and I'd be happy to answer them.

When possible, do use the Student Enrollment Certificate to set up your bank account. However, in a situation where you need to open a bank account before Freshers' Week, please contact Sarah (grants@lincoln.ox.ac.uk) for a bank letter.

You may find the ranking made by one of the previous Reps useful when deciding where to open your account:



Essentials

Phones

The most convenient option is to get a UK phone number once you arrive in Oxford. Some services may require you to register using a UK number. Vodafone, EE, O2 and Three are some of the main UK phone providers.

The two main options for a phone plan are:

- Pay-as-you-go: you purchase the plan outright and then buy credit (top-ups) as needed for calls, texts, and data.
- Contract plan: you pay a fixed monthly fee that includes a set allowance of minutes, texts, and data.

Some Telco companies (most of the main providers like EE and Vodafone) may require you to have a UK bank account, so check if this is necessary beforehand.

I personally use EE as I'm planning on keeping my UK number long term; however, many other international students use GiffGaff's or VOXI's 'monthly rolling' plan, which they can cancel at any time without incurring any fees or being obligated to continue (which may be useful whenever you return home and don't have to keep paying for the SIM). You may also want to check with second-years about which providers they may recommend, as Oxford's cell (especially around the city center) is notoriously spotty.

You will also have access to a uni-wide Wifi (Eduroam) and separate Lincoln College Wifi. Being able to access Wifi almost anywhere means you don't have to worry about the ability to make international phone calls with your plan – you can use WhatsApp or Messenger to call home instead!

Laundry

Laundry rooms (with both laundry machines and dryers), which Freshers use, are located in Chapel Quad and in Staircase 15 (which is connected to Lincoln House). You can top up online after making an account or pay as you go using the machines in the laundry room. We offer cheap laundry (compared to most UK unis, so I've heard), and since it's so close to accom it is really convenient :)

Medical Services

- The NHS is UK's healthcare system. If you are coming here on a student visa then you will have paid an IHS (immigration health surcharge) as part of your visa application (check the [website](#) to see if this applies to you).
- **If you're in a life-threatening situation, call 999**
- You should use the NHS **111** service if you urgently need medical help or advice but it's not a life-threatening situation.
- Before you arrive, you will also have to register with a GP at King Edward Street at the Northgate Medical Practice. You can make an appointment with them either online or by calling 01865 242657.
- The college nurse (Kinneret Milgrom) is also available in weeks 0-9, Tuesday - Friday, from 12.40 to 2.30. There is no need to make an appointment; you can just drop in, email (nurse@lincoln.ox.ac.uk), or book an appointment [here](#).

Welfare

- Lincoln's Welfare Team is led by the lovely Lisa Stokes-King, who is the Welfare Coordinator. You can drop in at any time (Monday to Friday in weeks 0-9) or [book a meeting](#) beforehand. Lisa's office is in Staircase 4, Room 2.
- You can also contact our JCR Welfare Officers: Mara Cook and Henry Drewitt-Jones. They are amazing if you're feeling stressed or just need a chat. If you're unsure who to reach out to with your issue, they can listen and identify the best person to refer you to!
- Our Chaplain, Revd Dr Jonny Torrance is also a great person to talk to and his door is open to anyone. You can find him in his room above the JCR (Staircase 5 Room 2).
- Outside of College, some helpful resources include: Oxford Nightline number (01865 270270), Samaritans UK (116 123). More information can be found on www.mind.org.uk.

Packing

Moving into College

Moving to University means you will have to bring a lot of things with you. Bringing more suitcases may be the more secure option than shipping boxes (especially if sending from outside the EU). However, if you decide to send your stuff, let the Lodge know beforehand. Sometimes your package may arrive before you, and that's not an issue, but it is always better to email and ask! I personally lugged ~2 suitcases (and a carry-on) from Heathrow to college, and bought the rest here.



Packing for UK Weather

The UK is known for its cold, rainy weather, so it's important to keep this in mind when packing. Older buildings, in particular, can get quite cold, and occasionally, the heating in older libraries might not work properly. Because of this, it's a good idea to pack some extra warm pieces:

Thermal wear: although you arrive in Oxford in October, which is still quite nice, Michaelmas lasts until early December, meaning it will get really cold before you know it. This was a must for me, moving from California!

Puffer jacket: you can bring one from home or buy one with a college crest and your initials (The Stash Rep will send a link in Michaelmas).

Blankets: they are a really cosy addition to your room and will keep you warm during the night :)



Packing

Oxford Specific

There are a few Oxford-specific things you should keep in mind while packing:

1. **Sub fusc:** this is the formal outfit worn during any formal University ceremonies, e.g. Matriculation and exams. More info can be found [here](#). You will be able to buy your gown when you get to Oxford, so don't worry about it for now. Your sub fusc also includes a white shirt and a black skirt or trousers (for girls) or a dark suit (for guys), so pack a few sets. This is also a good smart outfit, which you might need for some events. Your gowns can be purchased at Shepherd and Woodward, Ede and Ravenscroft, or Walters of Oxford.
2. **Formal dress:** you may not expect how many formal events you will attend during your time in Oxford. Among others, you will go to formal dinners, Black Tie Drinks, and any balls! You obviously don't need a different outfit for each event, but it's always good to have one or two options. This can be a bit expensive, so I highly recommend buying second-hand, getting one really good quality suit you can rewear, or swapping dresses with your friends, etc.
3. **Bop outfits:** sometimes you will attend bops and socials that require you to dress up in silly costumes. So, if space allows, consider packing one or two accessories! If not, you can always buy stuff once you're already in Oxford (e.g. on Amazon)





Feeling at Home
away from Home

Adjusting to Differences

Food

British food often gets a bad reputation, though in reality, much of the criticism is exaggerated (I personally love a Sunday Roast and Shepherd's Pie). Still, it can be comforting to bring some of your favourite snacks from home, especially for times when you're feeling homesick. Supermarkets like Tesco and Sainsbury's typically have international aisles with a decent selection, but you can find some speciality stores in Oxford too; I like to go to Seoul Plaza (which is a 2-minute walk) for East Asian snacks that remind me of home. Oxford also has a diverse selection of restaurants, and so don't be too concerned!

As the JCR Food Rep this year, please also let me know if you have any concerns or suggestions for the college's food options this year.

a lot of affordable, diverse restaurants
are located on Cowley Road!



Drinking

Drinking culture is a noticeable part of student life in the UK. Alcohol is relatively affordable, and social drinking is quite common, which may be different from what you're used to back home. However, it's important to know that you should never feel pressured to drink. People are usually respectful and don't push the non-drinkers, so please feel comfortable to (and do!) share your personal preferences. If you do choose to drink, make sure you know your limits and don't feel the need to keep up with others.

Remember, even if you don't drink, there are still plenty of ways to be part of the social scene. At Lincoln, the Entz Team always provides non-alcoholic options like soft drinks and mocktails at college events. The culture is generally friendly and open, so feel free to be yourself and talk to new people. At the end of the day, making friends comes down to being open and making the effort to reach out, and you should never feel pressured to drink as a means to do so.

Combating Homesickness

It's Okay To Struggle!

I'll begin this section with a personal anecdote. I didn't think I'd get homesick at all since I was so busy throughout Michaelmas with the excitement that moving to a new country and studying at Oxford brought. But in Hilary – once the sun began setting at 4 pm and the academic pressure ramped up – homesickness hit me all at once, to the point '500 Miles' by Peter, Paul and Mary was my most played song of the past year. All this is to say, no matter if or when it happens, it's completely normal to experience homesickness, and I understand how difficult it may be, especially on top of any imposter syndrome that being at an institution like Oxford may entail.

My simplest advice for dealing with homesickness is to make sure to set aside time to call your family or close friends from home and make it part of your daily or weekly routine – don't forget the love and support you have at home! Sometimes even the smallest things remind that you are not in your home country and bring on a wave of homesickness, and that's totally normal and completely valid. So don't be hard on yourself, it's okay to feel a bit overwhelmed. Remember that people are here to help. College welfare (Lisa) or the JCR Officers are a great place to start if you just need a chat.

Joining International Societies

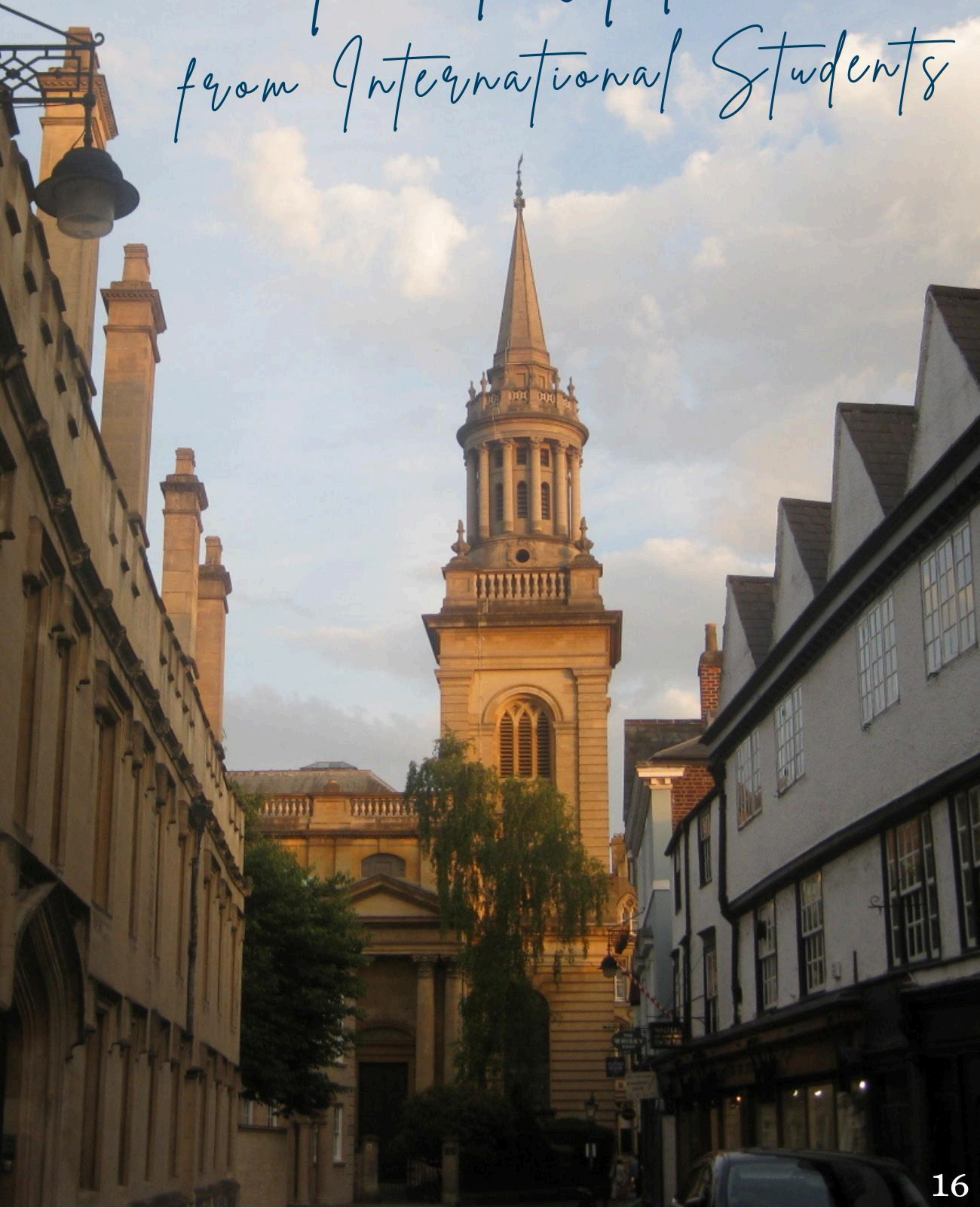
The easiest way of keeping in touch with your home country is to join a society. Oxford has a wide variety of cultural and international societies that represent people from around the world. This is an excellent opportunity to connect with others who share similar backgrounds, make new friends, and ease feelings of homesickness. The societies are very casual and are an opportunity for people from similar backgrounds to bond.

Some societies even organise uni-wide events, such as Balls or Black Tie parties (e.g. European Night). Many of Lincoln's international students in my year are involved with societies like the Asia-Pacific Society (OUAPS), the Malaysian and Singaporean Students' Association (OUMSSA), the Hindu Society, or have informal ties to other international student groups, and so please don't be afraid to reach out if you need a friend to go to a society event with.



Lincolnnites at APS welcome drinks!

Final Advice from International Students



The most important thing to remember is that what you are doing is incredible. Most people will be moving to a new city, but on top of that, you are moving to a new country. Remember it's ok to feel overwhelmed, nervous, anxious, scared and many more. But also remember that you are not alone, and there are others around you going through a similar experience



Communicate with the other years! It's often a shock, but being able to have a chat with 2nd years and above about the transition has been really helpful



Coming as an international student is always daunting, so don't be afraid to reach out to other international students and make a lot of friends during Freshers' Week, as it will make everything more welcoming



Remember even if we all speak the same language, there are loads of different ways of speaking, and some are very particular to Oxford. So don't worry if things are sometimes lost in translation, in both what the words actually mean and how they are intended to be meant. If in doubt, sometimes best to ask for clarification!

and some practical advice :)

Don't overpack because you'll be moving in and out every term!

Get the bank account process started as soon as you can. they can be slow. Don't hesitate to ask home students, they're happy to help with adapting too, but leave time to adjust so you're not stressed about both the move and the start of uni all at once

Make time to explore shops, supermarkets, public transport and restaurants early on, because life in the UK will be different from life at home. If you do this at the beginning, you won't have to worry about it later

I'd recommend Lloyds for a student bank account because opening accounts with other banks is way more complicated



See You in October!